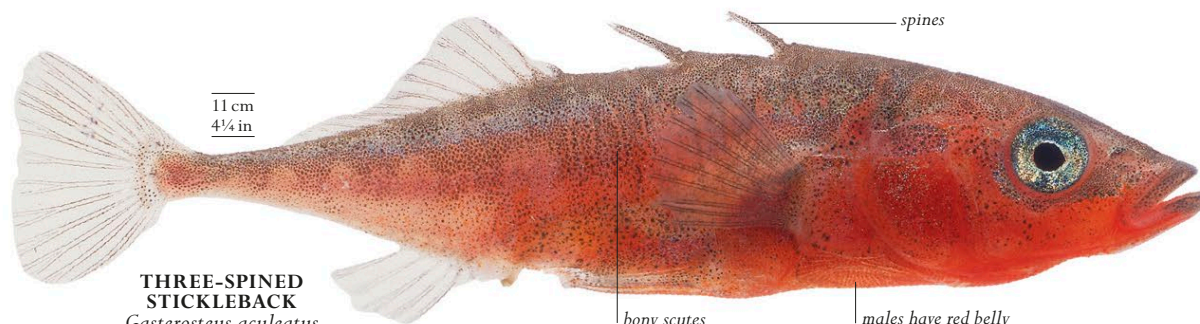


STICKLEBACKS AND SEAMOTHS

Most sticklebacks inhabit still and slow-moving fresh water, but some live in the sea as do seamoths. The Gasterosteiformes have a long, thin, stiff body protected by bony scutes (plates) along the sides and sharp spines along the back.



THREE-SPINED STICKLEBACK
Gasterosteus aculeatus
F: Gasterosteidae

This little fish is widespread in fresh water and shallow seas in the northern hemisphere. The male performs an elaborate courtship dance.

SEAMOTH
Eurypegus draconis
F: Pegasidae

Unlike the closely related sticklebacks, the tropical marine seamoth is flat and has large wing-like pectoral (side) fins.



CLINGFISH AND RELATIVES

Clingfish are small, usually marine, bottom-dwelling fish. Most of the Gobiesociformes possess a sucker formed from modified pelvic fins with which they cling to rocks. Their eyes are set high on the head and they have one dorsal fin.

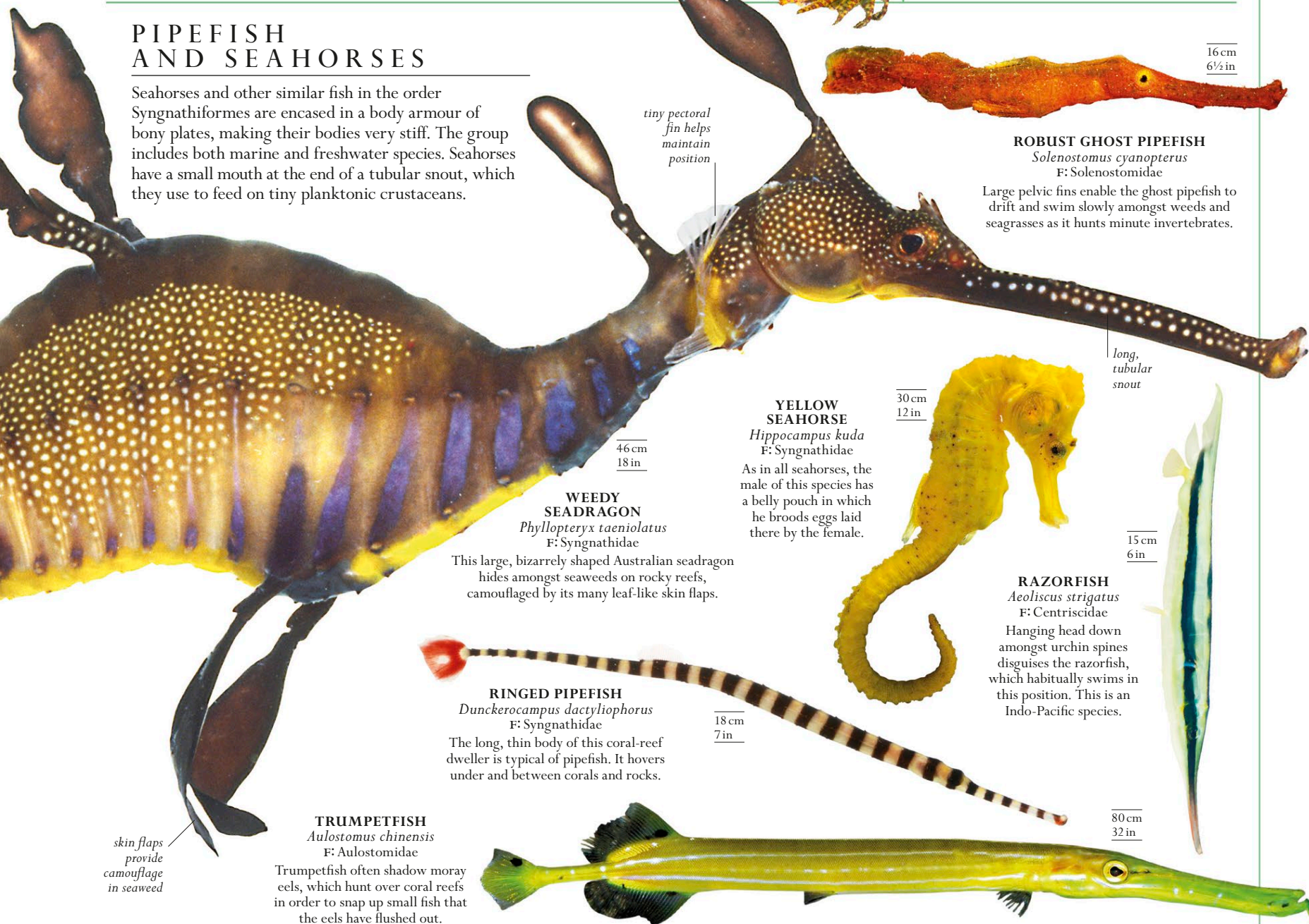


CONNEMARA CLINGFISH
Lepidogaster candolii
F: Gobiesocidae

Living in rocky shallows in the N.E. Atlantic, this little fish is exposed to strong waves, but can cling on tightly.

PIPEFISH AND SEAHORSES

Seahorses and other similar fish in the order Syngnathiformes are encased in a body armour of bony plates, making their bodies very stiff. The group includes both marine and freshwater species. Seahorses have a small mouth at the end of a tubular snout, which they use to feed on tiny planktonic crustaceans.



WEEDY SEADRAGON
Phyllopteryx taeniolatus
F: Syngnathidae

This large, bizarrely shaped Australian seadragon hides amongst seaweeds on rocky reefs, camouflaged by its many leaf-like skin flaps.

tiny pectoral fin helps maintain position

YELLOW SEAHORSE
Hippocampus kuda
F: Syngnathidae

As in all seahorses, the male of this species has a belly pouch in which he broods eggs laid there by the female.

30 cm
12 in

ROBUST GHOST PIPEFISH
Solenostomus cyanopterus
F: Solenostomidae

Large pelvic fins enable the ghost pipefish to drift and swim slowly amongst weeds and seagrasses as it hunts minute invertebrates.

16 cm
6 1/2 in

long, tubular snout

RAZORFISH
Aeoliscus strigatus
F: Centriscidae

Hanging head down amongst urchin spines disguises the razorfish, which habitually swims in this position. This is an Indo-Pacific species.

15 cm
6 in

RINGED PIPEFISH
Dunckerocampus dactyliophorus
F: Syngnathidae

The long, thin body of this coral-reef dweller is typical of pipefish. It hovers under and between corals and rocks.

18 cm
7 in

TRUMPETFISH
Aulostomus chinensis
F: Aulostomidae

Trumpetfish often shadow moray eels, which hunt over coral reefs in order to snap up small fish that the eels have flushed out.

skin flaps provide camouflage in seaweed

80 cm
32 in